

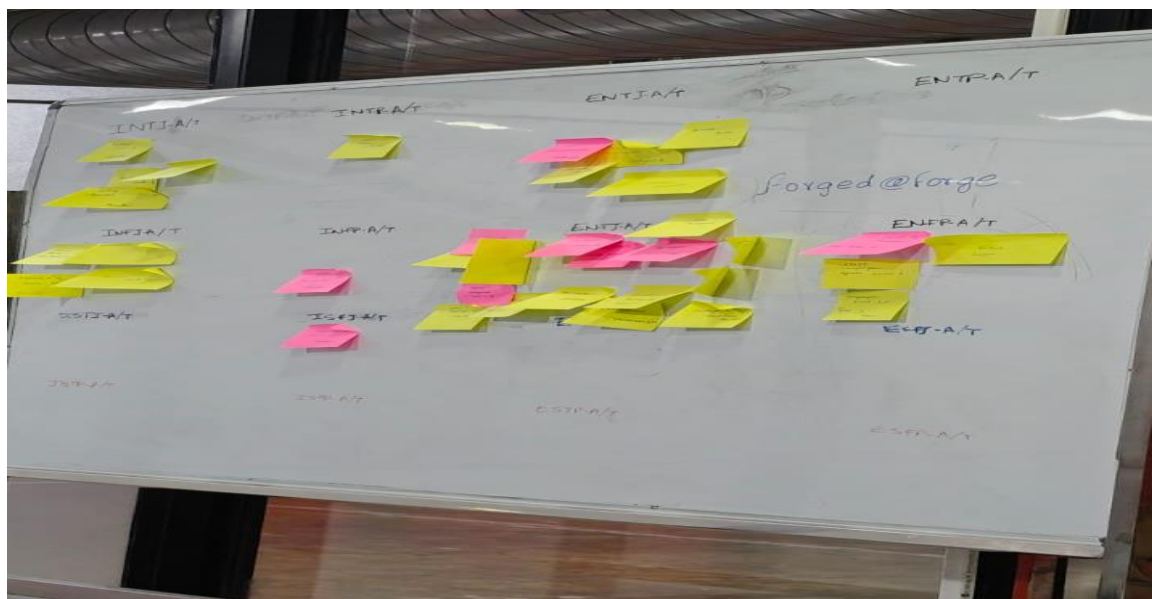
What happens when you bring students from Arts, Engineering, Computer Science, and distinct academic backgrounds into a single room and ask them to build together?

By Friday afternoon, the room looked completely different. We were no longer isolated individuals defending our discipline's way of doing things—we were a connected, agile team. Here is the story of our first five days at **Protosem**, how we navigated the transition from strangers to collaborators, and the lessons that reshaped our perspective along the way.

Day 1: Breaking Barriers & Seeing Problems

We kicked off Week 1 with 360° self-introductions and a high-energy Rock–Paper–Scissors networking challenge. While it started as a lighthearted icebreaker, it accomplished something crucial: it broke down the invisible walls we usually keep up in academic settings and pushed us out of our comfort zones.

Key Takeaway: Connection and keen observation are the true starting points of meaningful problem-solving. You can't solve a problem you haven't genuinely listened to.



Day 2: Understanding Ourselves Through Stories

Theme: Discover & Reflect

Day 2 moved inward. We started by exploring the **16 Personalities** framework, identifying our cognitive styles—from Protagonists and Advocates to Commanders and Analysts.

Next, we explored Gen Z web stories and comics, each selecting and presenting a narrative that resonated with our personal or academic journeys. Listening to everyone explain *why* a particular story struck a chord with them revealed something profound: diversity isn't just about different college majors or resumes; it's about the unique lenses through which people perceive, feel, and interpret the world.

Key Takeaway: Embracing cognitive diversity means recognizing that disagreements aren't roadblocks—they are different perspectives looking at the same reality.



As an ENFJ (Protagonist), you possess a unique blend of charisma, empathy, and idealism that sets you apart in any crowd. Your natural ability to inspire and lead others is matched only by your deep-seated desire to make a positive impact on the world around you. You have an uncanny knack for understanding people's emotions and motivations, often sensing what others need before they even realize it themselves.

Your gift for communication allows you to articulate your visionary ideas with passion and conviction, drawing others into your orbit and motivating them to join your cause. You thrive on meaningful connections and have a remarkable talent for bringing out the best in those around you. However, your idealistic nature can sometimes set you up for disappointment when reality falls short of your lofty expectations.



Energy: **54% Extraverted** ?

Extraverted ————— Introverted

Mind: **52% Intuitive** ?

Intuitive ————— Observant

Nature: **57% Feeling** ?

Thinking ————— Feeling

Tactics: **51% Judging** ?

Judging ————— Prospecting

Identity: **51% Turbulent** ?

Assertive ————— Turbulent

Day 3: Becoming a Team & Hands-on Prototyping

Theme: Collaborate & Build

Midweek brought the formation of our official **Beta Teams**. To break any lingering awkwardness, an *Among Us*-inspired deduction challenge tested our communication, active listening, and intuition under pressure.

Then came the classic **Spaghetti Tower Challenge**. Armed only with fragile dry spaghetti sticks, masking tape, string, and a single marshmallow destined for the top, the clock started ticking. We experienced early structural collapses, rapid pivots, and constant negotiation of ideas.

Key Takeaway: We stopped being separate people sitting at the same table and became a team that builds, tests, and iterates together.



Day 4: Exploring AI & Purposeful Technology

Theme: Explore & Elevate

Technology is only as effective as the intention behind it. On Day 4, a TED-style talk on modern AI workflows challenged us to move past generic prompting and view AI tools as specialized instruments for specific tasks.

We explored how tailoring and personalizing AI frameworks can amplify brainstorming, research, and rapid prototyping without replacing human critical thinking.

Key Takeaway: Don't use technology just because it's new—use the right tool with deliberate intention to solve the right problem.



Day 5: The Spark of Entrepreneurship

Theme: Ignite & Envision

We concluded our first week with the official inauguration of the **Youth Entrepreneurship Program (YEP)**. The highlight of the day was an insightful address by **Mr. M. Ramakrishnan, Founder & MD/CEO of Thulasi Pharmacies**.

Hearing his real-world journey of building a customer-centric enterprise from the ground up grounded everything we had learned all week. It connected our classroom exercises to genuine societal impact, sustainable business practices, and long-term resilience.

Key Takeaway: Great ventures aren't born in isolation; they are built when empathy, disciplined execution, and a clear purpose meet real market needs.



5 Core Lessons We're Taking Forward

1. **Connection First:** Real collaboration only begins after you cultivate trust and openness.
2. **Empathy-Driven Problem Identification:** The most impactful solutions come from deeply observing daily friction points.
3. **Cognitive Synergy:** Diverse personalities and backgrounds are a superpower when aligned toward a shared goal.
4. **Iterative Action Over Perfection:** Building messy prototypes teaches you faster than endless theoretical debates.
5. **Intentional Innovation:** Whether leveraging advanced AI or designing a business model, purpose must always lead technology.

Looking Ahead

Week 0 at Protosem proved that interdisciplinary learning is more than an academic buzzword—it is a mindset. As we transition into the next phase of deep-dive problem solving and prototyping, we carry forward a shared identity, a strong foundation of trust, and the confidence to create together.

“Protosem didn’t just teach us new concepts. It taught us how different people can connect, think differently, and build together.”